

26, The Principal Characteristics of the Feudalization Process, to Facilitate Observation

Up to this point, essentially all regions globally worthy of observation under the central theme of **feudalization** (封建化) have been considered by us. Therefore, for the purpose of controlling the length of this work, I will no longer conduct highly detailed macroscopic investigations into specific regions hereafter.

Some might notice that regarding the Scandinavia (斯堪的纳维亚) region—perhaps also including Scotland (苏格兰) in the northern part of the British Isles (不列颠岛) and the more distant Iceland (冰岛)—such a not-insignificant expanse of northern Europe was identically categorized by me into the historical process of participating in the great migrations (*or more accurately, the "barbarian invasions" [蛮族入侵]*) during previous discussions. However, the barbarian invasions originating from this region were glaringly different from those in Western Europe (西欧), because empirically, Western Europe was the invaded party, while Northern Europe (北欧) was the active invader. Conversely, those peoples living in the regions attacked by the Vikings (维京人) during their absolute zenith never persistently and deeply invaded the Vikings' homeland.

One might ask: Given this, how did the **feudalization** process unfold in northern Europe?

I maintain that although the historical trajectory of northern Europe was relatively unique, considering its geographical location, it is not fundamentally surprising. For a period following the collapse of the Western Roman Empire (西罗马帝国), the North Sea (北海) region did not advance to the **early state** (早期国家) stage; it remained in a condition defined by a multitude of tribal clans. By the time the Vikings commenced massive, widespread plundering, it was already the latter half of the Early Middle Ages (中世纪早期) (*specifically, the European Middle Ages*); the universal **feudalization** of Northern Europe only commenced when Western Europe had already entered the High Middle Ages (中世纪盛期).

Due to its geographical proximity to Western Europe and the exceptionally frequent violent and non-violent exchanges, advanced production technologies continuously disseminated into the Northern European region, resulting in an exceedingly rapid elevation of **productive forces** (生产力). Furthermore, Northern Europe belonged to the absolute periphery of the world at that time, constituting a negligible terminus within the global trade network (*from the High Middle Ages onwards, commercial trade here was no longer negligible*). The topography was also excessively fractured, with the population overwhelmingly concentrated along the protracted, rugged coastlines. On the eve of conversion to Christianity (基督教), the social structure of the Northern European region remained relatively simple; at the very least, compared to the conditions preceding the genesis of other **classical states** (古典国家), it fundamentally lacked a rigorous, explicitly defined social hierarchy.

These factors were entirely detrimental to the formation of a **classical state** capable of maintaining stability over a specific period in Northern Europe. Therefore, a direct transition to a **feudal society** (封建社会) was profoundly natural. As we previously pointed out when examining southern India, the dual decline of the monarch's **despotic power** (专制权力) and the state apparatus's **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) brought about by **feudalization** strictly applies to those regions that passed through a typical **classical period**. For regions that circumvented a typical **classical**

society (古典社会) and proceeded directly to **feudalization**, even early **feudal systems** (封建制度) and ideologies are highly beneficial for augmenting both of the monarch's powers!

Consequently, it was an entirely rational decision aligned with their interests for the rulers of the Northern European region to welcome **feudalization**. Just as one observes that the earliest cohort of Northern European kings who converted to Christianity were frequently canonized as saints post-mortem, the rulers and feudalism (封建主义) were genuinely moving towards each other in a mutual embrace. Chronologically, although the **feudalization** of Northern Europe occurred considerably later than that of Western Europe, if compared with Japan, it was roughly a concurrent historical phenomenon.

Compared to Eastern Europe (东欧), which commenced **feudalization** around substantially the same period, Northern Europe possessed a not-insignificant area, but its land available for agricultural reclamation was severely restricted. This precisely spared it from the existential peril of excessive **serfdom** (农奴制) development following the rise of the commercial and industrial economy in Western Europe, and the threat from nomadic peoples was even more non-existent. Considering further that Northern Europe was phenomenally receptive to the influence of advanced factors from Europe, both geographically and religiously, it is utterly unsurprising that it now belongs to the ranks of developed regions. The fact that contemporary Nordic countries are not merely developed, but rank at the absolute forefront globally in the Human Development Index, is likely due to factors functioning since the modern era; as I am unfamiliar with this, I will not elaborate further here.

Therefore, based on the preceding tens of thousands of words of discussion, it is fundamentally not difficult to discover that although human civilization possesses a rich and colorful plurality, the historical developmental trajectories across various global regions concurrently adhere to a universal underlying law.

Naturally, we must not forget that the "leapfrog development" (跨越式发展) of Northern Europe possessed considerable particularity.

First, there was fundamentally no geographical barrier isolating Northern Europe from Western Europe, a region already undergoing preliminary **feudalization**; personnel and materials could directly engage in high-intensity exchanges. We can observe that around the year 1000 AD, historical records already document a substantial number of mercenaries from Northern Europe operating across the entirety of Europe. This definitively distinguished it from the circumstances of Sub-Saharan Africa (撒哈拉以南非洲). During the initial centuries of contact with the newly formed Islamic world (伊斯兰世界) to the north, the contact patterns of Sub-Saharan Africa were exceptionally indirect. Commercial trade was primarily transferred through nomads in the desert (such as the *Tuareg people* [图阿雷格人]), and the earliest geographical information consisted entirely of second-hand data. Even between 1000 and 1300 AD, direct travel between the two regions remained an endeavor considered only by a minority of merchants and explorers.

Second, at the precise historical juncture when Northern Europe and Western Europe made contact, Western Europe was traversing the Early Middle Ages. The **feudal states** (封建国家) of this period were still in their formative stage; their organizational capacity remained relatively weak, projecting a comparatively introverted, defensive posture externally. During the Early Middle Ages, it was the

Northern Europeans, not the Western Europeans, who appeared as aggressors within the long river of history.

This, in turn, forms an exceptionally stark contrast with the Americas (美洲). When the Americas made contact with Europe, European nations had universally concluded their **feudal stage** and entered the phase of **early modern society** (近世国家). Not only was there an astronomical chasm in technology between the two sides, but the advanced party possessed a ferocious, overwhelming desire for conquest, fundamentally depriving the backward party of any opportunity to learn and develop. Analyzed from this perspective, Northern Europe was undeniably and exceptionally fortunate.

The so-called economic **feudalization** (封建化) is fundamentally a state where the growth of the level of **productive forces** (生产力水平) propels society into a condition in which small-scale production (*household production*) and the **natural economy** (自然经济) secure a decisive advantage in efficiency, and the tenancy system becomes the most effective mode of exploitation at the time.

(Naturally, this assertion that "the natural economy held an advantage in efficiency" is not entirely precise. No matter how advanced a classical empire might be, it could never compare to post-early modern regimes. Although the commodity economy within a classical empire was developed, the natural economy likely still constituted the majority. It is simply that when feudalization commenced, the substantial commodity economy of classical society suffered severe regression).

Beyond the primary factor of productive forces, we have previously identified several factors that influenced the emergence of this morphology. For instance, excessively vibrant commercial trade undeniably obstructs the natural economy from securing a dominant position.

Economic **feudalization** naturally catalyses a trend toward political **feudalization**, but this is not invariably realized. **This is the single most critical historical reality I wish to elucidate through these four hundred thousand words: a bureaucratic system (官僚体制) that fails to disintegrate normally will identically suffocate the genesis of a feudal system (封建体制).**

The definitive marker of the completion of political **feudalization** is the formation of the **feudal political system** (封建政治体制) represented by England and France during the High Middle Ages (中世纪盛期) in Western Europe (西欧). Naturally, we recognize that globally, only Western Europe and Japan reached this precise stage. Other regions, provided they were not excessively backward, invariably exhibited tendencies toward **feudalization** during diverse historical periods, yet due to myriad reasons, they failed to incubate a feudal system analogous to that of Europe.

However, the volume of historical documents preserved across various global regions fluctuates significantly, as does their reliability. Frequently, it is not particularly easy for scholars to definitively determine the predominant **production mode** (生产方式) or how exploitation was executed in a specific region at a specific historical moment. Therefore, when observing the history of various regions during their **feudal period** (封建时期), scholars habitually rely upon certain macroscopic characteristics that **feudalization** imposes upon the entire society.

Yet, as previously demonstrated, many of the so-called characteristics of **feudalization** actually reflect the morphological transformations that occur as a society transitions from a relatively typical **classical society** (古典社会) toward a **feudal society** (封建社会). However, a region prior to

feudalization was not necessarily a typical **classical society**—such as Scandinavia (斯堪的纳维亚) and Southern India (南印度). Therefore, observers must absolutely avoid the fallacy of rigidly applying criteria without regarding evolving circumstances (刻舟求剑). Scandinavia and Southern India never experienced any urban decline or a reduction in **despotic power** (专制性权力) and **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) during their **feudalization** processes. Could one legitimately claim they did not undergo **feudalization**?

The first universally recognized and most easily observable phenomenon is urban decline. This occurred because the development of the **natural economy** caused the commercial circulation necessary to sustain urban existence to recede. The atrophy of urban life was universally observed during the terminal phase of the classical era and the early feudal era, most conspicuously in Rome (罗马)—whether within the borders of the Western or Eastern Empire—a phenomenon European scholars have long comprehended thoroughly.

Urban decline identically materialized in Japan (日本), but its manifestation was exceptionally peculiar. This was due to Japan prematurely introducing China's bureaucratic system, and specifically, the bureaucratic system of the restoration period. The "urban decline" in Japan during the late Heian period (平安后期) primarily manifested as the decay of the settlements formed under the mandates of the Ritsuryo system (律令制) and the terminal nodes of local administration—namely, the *Gunke* (郡衙 / county offices; here, the so-called "county" [郡] refers to the administrative unit subordinate to the province [令治国] under the Japanese Ritsuryo system). I happened to discover this entirely by chance while reading the eighth chapter, *The Transformation of Regional Society* (《地域社会的转变》), of the Kodansha Japanese History series, *The Transformation of the Ritsuryo State: From the Nara Period to the Early Heian Period* (《律令国家的转变：奈良时代到平安时代前期》).

Clearly, the so-called urban decline in Japan differed astronomically from that in Europe. In Japan, political factors were exceptionally pronounced because the Ritsuryo system was *de facto* abandoned during the Heian period. The decline of local settlements during the Heian period even preceded the Insei (院政 / Cloistered Rule) era. Conversely, during the early Kamakura period (镰仓时代前期) following the conclusion of the Insei, the Japanese archipelago experienced no conspicuous urban decline. In reality, this specific period was the genuine early feudal era subsequent to the conclusion of the classical era. Although the Japanese—especially the Japanese of that era—might not necessarily perceive it this way, the historical reality is that Japan's **feudalization** process was remarkably moderate. Although the samurai (武士) class did not lack instances of rebelling against the imperial court, exiling the Emperor (天皇), and establishing alternative central authorities, in the final analysis, they organized a feudal regime squarely within the framework of the Japanese state.

In China, urban life also underwent a transformation since the late Eastern Han Dynasty (东汉后期). However, due to China's colossal scale, it is fundamentally impossible to generalize. In Northern China (北中国), from the end of the Han Dynasty to the Sixteen Kingdoms period (十六国时期), urban life generally regressed. It is merely that the urban decline during the terminal phase of the Chinese classical era was monumentally impacted by warfare. The proportion of population and societal wealth annihilated by the warlord chaos since the end of the Han Dynasty was something the Mediterranean world could not possibly compare with.

However, in Southern China (中国南方), because the history of development here was inherently shorter, a massive influx of population had already migrated from the north during the peaceful eras of the Han Dynasty, and the chaos of war further accelerated this demographic migration. Because the original urban life in the south during the classical era was already at a relatively low baseline, cities in the south actually continued to develop under the rule of the Eastern Wu (东吴) and the Jin Dynasty (晋朝).

The situation in India was similar to China's; its sheer mass precludes sweeping generalizations. Following the collapse of the Gupta Empire (笈多王朝), Northern India (北印度) might project an impression of urban life in decline, but this was impossible in Southern India. This was because Southern India not only never experienced a typical classical period, but under the stimulus of maritime trade, its cities actually became more prosperous.

However, in the Islamic world, the urban decline brought by *feudalization* was not sufficiently evident, because the entire Islamic world was in a state of excessive openness and commercial prosperity. Although some large cities were no longer what they used to be due to regime changes, the Islamic world overall did not experience the universal urban decay seen in *Europe* during the *Late Antiquity*.

Therefore, we can observe that the characteristic of urban decline associated with **feudalization** explicitly exhibits multiple disparate manifestations. In regions where classical cities were highly developed and the **natural economy** subsequently expanded rapidly, urban decline was phenomenally conspicuous. In regions where international trade remained perpetually developed, and where the classical period was less concentrated (chronologically) and less typical than those of the Han and Rome, perhaps some cities declined while new ones simultaneously arose, resulting in no overall regression. Conversely, when a **feudal economic system** (封建经济制度) was established in originally hyper-backward regions, urban development progressed continuously without interruption.

The second profoundly conspicuous mutation is the displacement of the "**lingua franca**" (四方通语) by **vernacular languages** (民族语言).

Here, the notion of a "lingua franca" during the classical period is not necessarily absolutely precise; on occasion, it did not manifest as a spoken language, but rather as a universally utilized script. However, unlike urban decline, the decay of the **classical lingua franca** (古典通语) was not completed at the very inception of **feudalization** (封建化). Based on observations of Europe, Ethiopia, and India, the classical lingua franca would continue to be extensively utilized as a religious language for a prolonged period following the commencement of feudalization.

The most quintessential paradigm occurred in the West. Latin (拉丁语), as the official language and lingua franca of the Roman Empire, was ultimately displaced by the vernacular languages of various nations in tandem with the progression of feudalization, despite the Catholic Church's persistent adherence to it during the Middle Ages. In Ethiopia, subsequent to the collapse of the Kingdom of Aksum (阿克苏姆王国), Ge'ez (吉兹语) remained in use for an extended period as the official language of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, yet vernacular languages represented by Amharic (阿姆哈拉语) surged following the feudalization of Ethiopia. Today, the positioning of Ge'ez in Ethiopia aligns fundamentally with that of Latin in Western Europe: both are ancient

languages utilized exclusively in religious contexts, and realistically, even within religious activities, this language is likely scarcely employed.

In India, the trajectory of Sanskrit (梵语) differed marginally, as it functioned primarily as a religious language from its inception; however, during the classical era, it likely functioned to some extent as a spoken language. Yet, alongside the asynchronously paced feudalization across the entirety of India, Sanskrit completely ceased to serve as a spoken tongue, calcifying into a written language deployed in realms such as academia and religion. Simultaneously, diverse regional vernaculars gradually evolved, metamorphosing into the vital instruments for quotidian communication among the populace. By the time European influence arrived in India, Sanskrit had already suffered severe degradation.

Even in regions where feudalization transpired but was less conspicuous, the displacement of the lingua franca by vernacular languages occurred to varying degrees. Today, the Iranian language family (伊朗语系) is delineated from west to east into Kurdish, Persian, Pashto, and so forth; the modern branches of the Turkic language family (突厥语系) identically function as the official languages of several Central Asian states, Turkey, and Azerbaijan. However, truthfully, because the history of the Middle East and Central Asia is phenomenally chaotic, rendering the establishment of stable **feudal states** (封建政权) fundamentally impossible, and compounded by the fact that Middle Persian and Middle Turkic were insufficiently typical as classical lingua francas, the Iranian and Turkic languages offer only limited reference value.

The circumstances in Southeast Asia are identical: neither Pali nor Khmer is utilized any longer to spell out vernacular languages. Japan's circumstances were relatively peculiar. After all, Japan, as an individual nation or civilization, possesses a relatively modest territorial expanse. It was exceedingly difficult for a classical language to be utterly displaced in quotidian usage by a multitude of regional folk dialects, as occurred with the aforementioned Latin and Sanskrit. Nevertheless, the characteristic that ought to manifest indeed materialized. For instance, during the Chūsei (中世 / Middle Ages), the linguistic disparity between the Emperor (天皇) and the court nobility (公卿) versus the language utilized by the samurai (武士) and commoners became starkly pronounced. The former conspicuously preserved more characteristics of classical Japanese—a linguistic divergence that remains perceptible even in Emperor Hirohito's (裕仁天皇) radio broadcast announcing Japan's surrender.

Conversely, in regions devoid of thorough feudalization, the classical lingua franca was not so easily supplanted by vernacular languages. For example, from Mauritania to present-day Iraq, the official language of an unbroken contiguity of nations remains Arabic, which tangentially reflects the insufficiency of feudalization within the Arab world.

The most quintessential paradigm remains China. China's classical lingua franca practically never vanished (*or more accurately, though it never vanished, it was perpetually evolving*). Classical Chinese (文言文) merely increasingly degenerated into a specialized format strictly deployed for drafting official documents. Yet even so, one can observe that the dialects most radically divergent from contemporary Mandarin and possessing the lengthiest divergence period within China—such as Hokkien (闽南语) and Hakka (客家语)—are distributed precisely in regions with a relatively high degree of feudalization, as vividly demonstrated by the Tulou (土楼) architecture in Fujian. Fundamentally, the myriad languages that can currently be categorized within the Sinitic family

(though within China, generally no one would invite trouble by explicitly stating this) are geographically distributed in regions of China where the degree of feudalization is relatively high. Naturally, in a locale entirely suppressed by the bureaucracy like China, one must employ a significantly lower metric: the mere presence of robust clan power is already sufficient to be deemed a relatively high degree of feudalization!

If we extend our gaze chronologically from earlier regions forward, Vietnam and Korea—having separated from China—identically ultimately developed their indigenous national scripts. Interestingly, however, the history of Vietnam furnishes a tragically farcical case study, intuitively exposing to the world exactly how proponents of **restoration-bureaucratic** rule perceive vernacular languages (and scripts), even their own!

Emperor Minh Mạng (明命帝阮福𢆏), the second emperor of Vietnam's Nguyễn Dynasty (阮朝), was a fanatical champion of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度). Although the era he inhabited undeniably belonged to the early modern period of the world, this individual authentically governed by taking the Qing Dynasty (清朝) as his paramount exemplar. Minh Mạng aggressively championed the Chinese language and Chinese literature, mandating that schools, governmental documents, and the civil service examinations unconditionally utilize Chinese characters (汉字), explicitly prohibiting the usage or intermingling of Chữ Nôm (喃字 / Vietnamese demotic script). During his attempt to conquer Cambodia, Emperor Minh Mạng identically enforced draconian assimilation policies, which included compelling Cambodians to adopt Chinese surnames, write in Chinese characters, and replacing indigenous toponyms with Chinese character names.

In stark antithesis to his veneration of Chinese characters and language, Minh Mạng violently suppressed Vietnam's national script, Chữ Nôm. Literary works composed in Chữ Nôm frequently exposed societal darkness, so it was fundamentally unsurprising that the bureaucratic rulers perceived it as inherently dangerous. Emperor Minh Mạng spent his entire life learning from the Chinese restoration empire and died in early 1841. In a certain sense, he undeniably succeeded: Vietnam's territorial expanse reached its absolute zenith during his reign, much like the Qing Dynasty also constituted the dynasty with the largest *de facto* controlled territory in Chinese history.

Yet, a mere year and a half after his demise, China was utterly crushed by Britain in the First Opium War (鸦片战争) and coerced into signing the Treaty of Nanking (《南京条约》). The colossal tide of human development is irrevocable. Yet Emperor Minh Mạng, even after centuries or millennia have passed, will likely secure a prominent position among the renowned "anachronistic reactionaries" (不识时务者) of all times and nations across the globe, purely due to his preposterously bizarre historical performance.

Beyond the two particularly conspicuous characteristics cited above, the **feudalization process** (封建化过程) brought about numerous other manifest changes to society, making it truly unnecessary to waste space enumerating them one by one.

One merely needs to perpetually remember that the societal impacts brought about during the **early stage of feudalization** (封建化早期) intuitively often belonged to the "negative" category, such as the further decline of female status (*driven by the necessity to construct stable patriarchal families*) and the collapse of social service institutions. However, this was absolutely not a genuine historical regression, nor did it signify that society had entered a Dark Age (黑暗时代) following its classical splendor. For regions that had already attained the **classical stage** (古典阶段), the disintegration and

subsequent reorganization of society during the feudalization process was phenomenally necessary; failing to complete this would constitute a genuinely boundless Dark Age. Such a counter-intuitive conclusion has deceived countless scholars over the past millennium; those who are already aware should constantly remind themselves not to repeat this exact mistake.

Furthermore, the outward manifestations of feudalization naturally did not appear exclusively during early feudal society; distinct characteristics emerged across different periods of **feudal society** (封建社会).

For instance, a highly renowned example is—the reason I say it is highly renowned is that even though China never experienced the period of **late feudal society** (封建社会晚期), this example enjoys considerable prominence even in China—the so-called "martial techniques" (武技) of the late feudal era and the dawn of the **early modern period** (近世早期), which was a form of martial arts where two combatants engaged each other holding weapons. During Japan's Sengoku period (日本战国时期) and the early Edo period (江户前期), these martial techniques generally manifested as various schools of swordsmanship (刀法流派) utilizing the katana, though martial arts utilizing other weapons also existed. In Europe, during the **Late Middle Ages** (中世纪晚期), the Renaissance (文艺复兴时期), and the early modern period, it is said that the German and Italian schools of swordsmanship were the most famous.

Initially, the primary weapon for combat was the two-handed sword, but this later mutated due to the demand for visual spectacle. Whether in Europe or Japan, that era witnessed the emergence of a vast cohort of martial arts masters who established their own sects, and a considerable number of enthusiasts continue to follow them today. **Feudal states** (封建国家) outside of Europe and Japan did not possess such massive cultural influence, making it difficult for me to learn about them from within China; however, it is said that such martial techniques indeed also existed in Thailand and Myanmar.

Why, then, did such systematic, sect-forming combat skills, which were widely sought after at the time, emerge during the terminal phase of the Middle Ages?

The fundamental reason lies in the fact that when society developed to this specific stage, **feudalism** (封建主义) had already begun to march toward decline. **Feudal samurai** (封建武士) or **knights** (骑士), serving as the former military pillars, were now experiencing a decline in their functional utility in warfare; various regimes substantially elevated their capacity to administer and integrate their territories, and commoners began to play an increasingly paramount role in war. However, the socio-political status of the samurai and knights was supported precisely by their military service; consequently, these societal mutations inevitably induced a profound sense of crisis.

This is exactly why martial techniques became broadly popularized toward the terminal phase of the Middle Ages: the pre-existing **lower-middle feudal ruling class** (中下层封建统治阶级) possessed an acute necessity to emphasize their martial superiority to prove the stability of their status. In earlier periods, this point fundamentally did not require any proof. By the even later **modern era** (近代), let alone participating in martial arts duels, even merely spectating them became a symbol of class identity.

For societies that never experienced a **complete feudalization process** (完整封建进程), it was naturally fundamentally impossible for such phenomena to exist, because there was simply no **warrior stratum** (武士阶层) experiencing anxiety over its own social status. Expecting a state like China to develop martial techniques utilizing weaponry is sheer wishful thinking, because the warrior subjects responsible for the flourishing of such techniques had been the very targets the imperial court detested most and strove to eradicate for over a millennium.

Even the development of martial arts utilizing fewer implements was massively obstructed. Although Chinese people today frequently boast about the ancient heritage of their nation's martial arts, even a fool can discern that the vast majority of Chinese martial arts only emerged during the **late Qing period** (晚清时期)—a time when the Qing government's capacity to violently suppress the grassroots had undeniably declined. Under normal circumstances, the martial arts philosophies and sects that germinated during the chaotic times of a late dynasty were fundamentally unlikely to survive the next pacified prosperous era of "clear rivers and calm seas" (“河清海晏”的盛世).

Aside from some relatively obvious characteristics, the multitude of cultural and artistic achievements catalyzed by the feudalization process—such as epic poems (长篇叙事诗) and *monogatari* (物语) extolling the martial exploits of feudal knights—will no longer be enumerated one by one. After all, China never completed this historical trajectory, and therefore it is exceedingly difficult for me personally to achieve a profound understanding of them.

26, 封建化过程的主要特征, 以方便人们进行观察

到这里为止, 全世界在“封建化”这个主题下值得观察的地区已经基本上都被我们考虑了一遍, 因此出于控制篇幅的目的, 这以后也就不再对于某个地区进行更加细致的考察。可能会有人注意到对于斯堪的纳维亚地区, 或许还要加入不列颠岛北部的苏格兰和更遥远的冰岛, 这样一个面积并不小的欧洲的北方, 之前讨论的时候我把它也归入了参与民族大迁徙(或者准确地说“蛮族入侵”)这个历史进程中的地方。但是这个地方的蛮族入侵显然与西欧不同, 因为从事实上看西欧是被入侵的一方, 北欧是主动入侵的一方。相反, 那些在维京人活动的鼎盛时期遭到维京人攻击的地区生活的民族, 从来没有持久深入地进攻过维京人的故乡。人们或许会问, 既然如此, 北部欧洲的封建化过程是怎么展开的呢? 我认为欧洲北部的历史进程虽然比较独特, 但是考虑到其地理位置倒也没什么值得奇怪的。在西罗马帝国灭亡之后一段时间, 北海地区并没有发展到早期国家阶段, 仍然处于氏族部落林立的状态。维京人开始大面积外出劫掠, 已经是中世纪早期(欧洲的中世纪)的后半段了; 北欧普遍的封建化则是西欧已经进入中世纪盛期才开始。因为与西欧地理上的接近以及暴力和非暴力交流的频繁, 先进的生产技术不断传播到北欧地区, 这里的社会生产力水平提高非常快。另外北欧在当时属于世界的边缘, 是世界贸易网络中微不足道的末端(从中世纪盛期开始, 这里的商业贸易就不再微不足道了)。地形也太过破碎, 人口多集中在漫长崎岖的海岸线附近。在皈依基督教前夕, 北欧地区的社会结构依然相对简单, 至少跟其他古典国家产生前的情况相比, 缺少严格的, 明确的社会等级制度。

这些因素都不利于北欧形成一个能够在一段时期内稳定的古典国家, 因此向封建社会直接过渡是很自然的。如同之前在考察南印度时我们就已经指出的, 封建化所带来的君主的专制权力与国家政权的基础性权力双重衰退是对于那些经过典型古典时期的地区而言的, 对于不经过典型古典社会而直接封建化的地区来说, 哪怕是早期的封建制度和意识形态对于增强君主的两项权力都是有益的。因此北欧地区的统治者对于封建化表示欢迎是合乎他们利益的决定, 就如同人们看到北欧最早一批皈依基督教的国王们往往被迫认为圣徒, 统治者和封建主义确实是在双向奔赴。至于从时间上看, 北欧的封建化虽然比西欧晚不少, 但是如果和日本相比, 那么大致也就是同一个时期的事情。北欧与基本同一时期开始封建化的东欧相比, 它的面积虽然不小, 但是可供开垦的农业用地着实有限, 免去了在西欧工商业经济兴起之后农奴制过度发展的危险, 游牧民族的威胁就更没有踪影了。再考虑到无论在地理上还是宗教上, 北欧都非常容易接受来自欧洲的先进因素的影响, 这里现在属于发达地区的序列并不奇怪。只不过现如今北欧国家不仅仅是发达, 而且人类发展指数位于世界前列, 这大概是近代以来的因素起到了作用, 我因为

不熟悉就不在这里多说了。因此基于以上几万字的讨论，我们不难发现虽然人类文明具有丰富多彩的多元性，但是世界各地的历史发展进程又遵循着一种普遍规律。

当然，我们不应忘记北欧的“跨越式发展”具有相当的特殊性。首先是北欧与西欧这一初步封建化的地区之间，没有地理上的天险阻隔，人员和物资会直接进行高强度的交流。我们可以看到在公元1000年前后，史料记载中就有不少来自北欧的雇佣兵在欧洲全境活动。这就与撒哈拉以南非洲的情况显著区分开来，撒哈拉以南非洲在与北方新形成的伊斯兰世界接触的头几个世纪里接触模式都是非常间接的。商业贸易主要通过沙漠中的游牧民（比如图阿雷格人）进行转手，最早的地理信息也都是二手资料，即使在公元1000到1300年间，直接来往于两地仍然是少数商人和探险家所考虑的事情。其次，北欧与西欧相接触的时候西欧正处于中世纪早期，这一时期的封建国家正处于形成阶段，组织能力还较弱，对外表现为相对内敛的防御姿态。在中世纪早期作为进攻者的形象出现在历史长河中的是北欧人，而不是西欧人。这又与美洲形成了非常鲜明的对比，当美洲与欧洲接触的时候，欧洲国家普遍结束了封建阶段进入近世国家。双方不但在技术上天差地别，而且先进的一方有非常强烈的征服欲望，根本就不会给落后一方学习和发展的机会。从这个角度来看，北欧无疑是相当幸运的。

所谓经济上的封建化从本质上而言就是生产力水平的增长使得社会进入了这样一种状态，即小规模生产（家庭生产）和自然经济在效率上取得了优势，租佃制成为当时最有效的剥削方式。（当然，这个“自然经济效率上占优势”的说法并不准确，因为古典帝国再发达，也不可能跟近代之后的政权比。古典帝国的商品经济虽然发达，但是恐怕自然经济还是占了多半，只不过当封建化开始后古典社会可观的商品经济也严重衰退了。）除了生产力水平这个主因以外，我们之前已经举出了一些影响这种形态出现的因素，例如商业贸易的过分活跃当然会阻碍自然经济占据主导地位。经济上的封建化自然会催生政治上封建化的趋势，但是这一点并不总是实现，这是我写这四十万字想指出的最重要的事实：没有正常瓦解的官僚体制也会遏制封建体制的产生。政治封建化完成的标志是形成西欧中世纪盛期以英、法为代表的封建政治体制。当然我们知道全世界毕竟只有欧洲西部和日本走到了这一步，其他地区只要不是太过落后，在不同时期都发生过了封建化的倾向，但是因为各种原因没有产生出欧洲那样的封建制度。然而世界各地所存留下来的历史文献数目不同，可靠度也有差异，很多时候人们没那么容易判断某地在某个时刻主要采取什么样的生产方式，剥削是怎么展开。因此在观察各个地区封建时期的历史的时候，人们会习惯于利用封建化对于整个社会带来的一些宏观的特征。但是就如之前已经表明的，很多所谓封建化的特征实际上反映的是从比较典型的古典社会向封建社会运动中社会形态所发生的变化，但是一个地区封建化之前不一定就是比较典型的古典社会，例如斯堪的纳维亚和南印度，因此人们在观察的时候绝对不能刻舟求剑。斯堪的纳维亚和南印度在封建化的过程中从来没有什么城市衰退，专制性权力和基础性权力出现下降的情况，难道能说它们没有封建化吗？

第一个众所周知的，也是人们最容易观察到的现象就是城市衰落，因为自然经济发展导致维持城市存在的流通开始消退了。城市生活的萎缩在古典时代结束时期以及封建时代早期被普遍观察到，最为显著的是罗马，无论是在西帝国还是东帝国境内，欧洲学者早就对此了解充分。在日本城市衰退也出现了，但是形式非常特别，这是由于日本在过早的阶段引入了中国的官僚制度，而且是复辟时期的官僚制度。日本在平安后期的“城市衰退”主要表现为律令制要求下形成的群落以及地方行政的末端，也就是郡衙（这里的所谓郡就是日本律令之下令治国更下一级的行政单位）的衰亡，我还是在看讲坛社的日本史系列《律令国家的转变：奈良时代到平安时代前期》第八章《地域社会的转变》的时候偶然得知。显然日本的所谓城市衰退和欧洲相比差异还是很大，前者的政治因素尤为明显，因为律令制在平安时期事实上就是被放弃了，平安时期的地方聚落衰退甚至发生在院政之前。反而在院政结束之后的镰仓时代前期日本列岛没有出现明显的城市衰退的情况，其实这才是古典时代结束后的封建早期。虽然说日本人特别是当年的日本人未必这样想，但事实就是日本的封建化进程已经相当缓和，武士不乏反抗朝廷，流放天皇，另立中央这样的行为，但是归根到底是在日本国家的框架内组织起了封建政权。

在中国，自东汉后期以来城市生活也发生了变化，不过，因为中国的庞大所以无法一概而论。在北中国，从汉末到十六国时期城市生活整体上是衰退的，只不过中国古典终结期城市的衰退受战争影响非常大，汉末以来军阀混战对于人口和社会财富销毁的比例是地中海世界不能够比的。但是在中国南方，因为这里的开发历史本身就比较短，汉代和平时期就已经有大量人口从北方移居到此，战乱更是进一步驱动了人口迁徙。因为在南方，古典时代原本的城市生活也就处于一个比较低的水平，在东吴以及晋朝统治下南方的城市还在发展。印度的情况与中国类似，体量过大而不可一概而论，在笈多王朝结束之后，

北印度或许会出现城市生活衰退的印象，但是在南印度就不可能了。因为后者不但没有经历过一个典型的古典时期，而且在海上贸易的影响下这里的城市更加繁荣。而在伊斯兰世界，封建化带来的城市衰退就不够明显了，因为整个伊斯兰世界都处于一种过于开放和贸易繁荣的状态。虽然有一些大城市会因为政权更迭大不如前，但是伊斯兰世界总体上没有出现过欧洲在古典时代晚期那种普遍性的城市衰退。因此，我们可以看到城市衰退这个封建化的特征显然有多种不同的表现形式，在古典城市发达而自然经济迅速发展的地方，城市衰退非常明显；在国际贸易始终发达，古典时期不如汉朝和罗马那样集中（在时间上）和典型的地方，可能是一些城市衰退了，又有一些城市兴起，总体来说没有衰退；而在原本非常落后的地区确立封建经济制度的时候，城市也是在始终发展的。

第二个非常显著的变化是“四方通语”被民族语言取代。这里所谓的古典时期的“四方通语”的说法不一定非常准确，有的时候不一定是一种语言，而是一种通用的文字。不过与城市衰退不同，古典通语的衰落并不是在封建化刚开始的时候就完成的，根据对于欧洲，埃塞俄比亚和印度的观察，在封建化开始得很长一段时期里古典通语都会作为宗教语言被广泛使用。最为典型的例子还是发生在西方，拉丁语作为罗马帝国的官方语言和通用语言，尽管中世纪时期的天主教会还在坚持，但是最终仍然随着封建进程的发展被各民族语言所取代了。在埃塞俄比亚，阿克苏姆王国覆灭之后，吉兹语作为埃塞俄比亚正教的官方语言依然使用了很长一段时间，但是以阿姆哈拉语为代表的民族语言在埃塞俄比亚封建化之后崛起了。现在吉兹语在埃塞俄比亚的定位和拉丁语在欧洲西部基本一致，都是只用在宗教中的古代语言，实际上即使是宗教活动中这种语言恐怕也很少使用了。在印度，梵语的情况略有不同，因为梵语在一开始就主要是作为一种宗教语言，不过，在古典时代，以前也可能一定程度上作为口语使用。但是随着印度全境节奏不同的封建化，梵语完全不再作为口语使用，成为一种用于学术、宗教等领域的书面语言，而各种地方俗语逐渐发展起来，成为人们之间日常交流的重要工具。在欧洲的影响抵达印度时，梵语已经严重衰落了。

即使是在封建化虽然进行，但是没有那么显著的地方，民族语言替代四方通语的情况也不同程度的发生了。现在的伊朗语系从西向东分为库尔德与伊朗语和普什图语等等，突厥语系的现代分支们同样成为中亚几个国家和土耳其、阿塞拜疆的官方语言。不过说实话，由于中东和中亚地区的历史实在太过混乱，根本就没办法建立稳定的封建政权，再加上中古波斯语和中古突厥语作为古典时代的四方通语也不够典型，伊朗语和突厥语只有有限的参考价值。东南亚的情况是一样的，不管是巴利语还是高棉语都不再用来拼读民族语言。日本的情况相对特殊，毕竟日本作为单独一个国家或者文明面积确实不算大，很难出现像之前提到的拉丁语和梵语那种古典语言在日常使用中许多种地域性的民间语言完全取代的情况。不过该出现的特征还是出现了，例如在中世时期，天皇和公卿使用的语言与武士和百姓使用的语言差别已经十分显著，前者很明显保留了更多古典日语的特征，这一点在裕仁天皇宣布日本投降的广播中甚至还能够听出来。

而对于没有充分封建化的地方，古典时期的四方通语就没有那么容易被民族语言所取代。例如从毛里塔尼亚到现在的伊拉克，一系列相连不断的国家官方语言都是阿拉伯语，这从侧面反映了阿拉伯世界封建化的不充分。最为典型的还是中国，中国的古典通语实际上就没有消失（换句话说，虽然没有消失却一直在演变），仅仅是文言文作为一种书写形式越来越沦为一种公文写作时才出现的格式。可即使如此，人们也能看到在中国与当代普通话差异最大的，分化时间可能最长的语言，例如闽南语和客家话，也是分布在封建化程度较高的地区，就像福建的土楼所显示的一样。基本上现在人们能从汉语族里面分出的各种语言（在中国国内一般不会有人自讨没趣说这个事情）从空间地理分布上看都存在于中国封建化程度比较高的地区。当然在中国这样整体被官僚体制压制的地方必须用更低的标准来衡量，宗族力量比较强就已经可以视为封建化程度比较高了。

如果我们把目光从更早的地方往后看，从中国脱离出来的越南、朝鲜也最终发展出了自己的民族文字。不过有意思的是越南的历史提供了一个让人啼笑皆非的案例，能够直观地向世人揭示那些复辟官僚统治的支持者是怎么看待各民族语言（文字），哪怕是自己民族语言（文字）的。越南阮朝的第二个皇帝明命帝阮福暉就是一个复辟官僚制度的狂热拥护者，虽然说他所处的时代毫无疑问已经是世界的近代，但是这个人的确是以清朝作为榜样执政。阮福暉非常支持汉语和汉文文学，要求学校教书，政府文字和科举考试一律要用汉字，不准使用或者混用喃字。在试图征服柬埔寨的过程中，明命帝一样推行严厉的同化政策，这就包括要求柬埔寨人改汉姓，写汉字，并且给各地更换上汉字地名。与推崇汉字和汉语相反，明命帝打压越南的民族文字喃字，用喃写字的文学作品揭露社会黑暗，官僚统治者认为其具有危险

性不奇怪。明命帝向中华复辟帝国学习了一辈子，死在 1841 年初，某种意义上他确实成功了，越南的版图在他统治时达到了最大，就好比清朝也是中国实控领土面积最大的一个朝代一样。然而就在他去世一年半之后，中国在鸦片战争中被英国彻底击败，被迫签订了《南京条约》。人类发展的潮流不可阻挡，但是明命帝恐怕即使再过几百上千年之后也能够因为其过于离奇的表现古今中外的知名“不识时务者”中占有重要地位。

除了上面举出的两个特别明显的特征以外，封建化过程给社会带来的明显变化还有很多，实在没有浪费篇幅一一列举的必要。人们只需要始终不要忘记的是，封建化早期所带来的社会影响在直观上往往属于“负面”的，例如女性地位的进一步下降（构建稳定父权家庭的需要），社会服务机构的崩溃等等。但是这绝非真正的历史退步，也不意味着在古典辉煌之后社会进入了一个黑暗时代，对于已经达到过古典阶段的地区而言，社会在封建化过程中瓦解并且重组是非常有必要的，如果完成不了那才是真正无边无际的黑暗时代。这样一种反直觉的结论在过去千百年里骗过了多少学者啊，已经知晓的人更应该时刻提醒自己不再重蹈覆辙。

另外封建化的外显特征当然不只是出现在封建社会早期，在封建社会的不同时期都会出现不同的表征。例如一个非常有名的例子是（之所以我说非常有名，是因为即使中国没有经历过封建社会晚期这个时期，但是这个例子即使在中国也很有知名度）封建时代晚期和近世早期的所谓“武技”，就是一种对战双方手持武器进行交战的武术。在日本战国时期和江户前期，这种武技一般是使用武士刀的各种刀法流派，但是也有使用其他兵器的武术。在欧洲的中世纪晚期、文艺复兴时期和近世，据说德国和意大利的剑术流派最为有名。最开始格斗的主要武器是双手剑，但是后来因为观赏性的要求发生了变化。无论是在欧洲还是在日本，那个时代都涌现了一大批武术大师开宗立派，现在还有不少爱好者追随。欧洲和日本以外的封建国家没有那么大的文化影响力，因此我在中国也难以了解，不过据说泰国和缅甸的确也存在这样的武技。

那么为什么这样系统化的，形成流派的，在当时广受追捧的格斗技巧出现在中世纪的晚期呢？原因在于，当社会发展到这个时期，封建主义已经开始走向衰落。封建武士或者骑士作为曾经的军事支柱，现在在战争中起到的作用正在下降，各个政权对于自己领地的管理和整合能力大幅提升，普通百姓在战争中发挥了越来越重要的角色。然而武士和骑士的地位恰恰是由其军事服役所支持的，因此社会的变化就会造成一种危机感。这就是为什么武技到了中世纪的结束阶段会广为流行，因为原有的中下层封建统治阶级非常需要强调其在军事上的优越性来证明自己地位稳固。而在更早的时期，这一点根本不需要证明。到了更晚的近代，不要说参与武术决斗，哪怕仅仅是观赏武术决斗都成为一种阶级身份的象征。对于没有经历过完整封建进程的社会，自然也就根本不可能存在这样的事情，因为这里压根就没有一个对自身的社会地位感到焦虑的武士阶层（中下层统治阶级）。像中国这样的国家要发展出使用兵器的武技简直是痴心妄想，因为导致武技兴盛的主体武士，一千多年来就是朝廷最为痛恨和力图消灭的对象。即使是较少使用器械的武术发展也受到极大阻碍，尽管今天中国人经常吹嘘自己国家的武术传承悠久，但是连傻瓜都能看出大部分中国武术也就是晚清时期才出现的，那个时候清朝政府对于基层的弹压能力确实是下降了。在正常情况下，王朝后期乱世中所萌发的武术思想和流派，基本上不太可能熬过下一个“河清海晏”的盛世。除了一些比较明显的特征外，封建化过程所催生的许许多多的文化和艺术成就，比如歌颂封建骑士武功的长篇叙事诗和物语，就不再一一列举，中国毕竟没有走完过这个历程，因此我本人也很难以做到十分了解。